

CREEPING KILLERS

The most numerous desert animals are insects, scorpions, and spiders. They can survive on relatively little food, making them well adapted to life in deserts. Many scorpions and spiders are highly venomous. This gives them an advantage when they do find prey—a single sting or bite makes escape impossible, and ensures that the hunter gets a meal.



NIGHTLIFE

Small animals such as mice, gerbils, ground squirrels, and kangaroo rats spend the hot days below ground, where the air is cooler and contains more moisture. They emerge at night to forage for food such as seeds, but have to avoid hunters such as foxes.



▲ MOUSE DETECTORS

The huge ears of the African fennec fox help it locate prey in the dark.

SIDE-WINDING

Reptiles can go for long periods without eating, and their scaly skins stop them from drying out. Many have very efficient ways of moving over soft sand. For instance, the side-winding motion of this desert viper helps it grip the loose surface.



HEAT PROTECTION

A few large mammals, such as camels, donkeys, and gazelles, manage to survive in deserts. Camels have special adaptations for dealing with the heat and drought. They can go for long periods without water, rarely sweat, and have humps on their backs where they store fat.

▼ NATURAL NOMADS

Camels wander the desert searching for edible plants.

